

Asia, by selling their profitable investments in India. Over the next one year, some of the foreign investors would withdraw altogether from India.

Until that time, mass layoffs were unheard of in the Indian broking industry. Particularly cruel was the manner in which Peregrine Securities fired its employees. Two officials from the Hong Kong office landed up at the Mumbai office for a review meeting. After the usual PowerPoint presentations, the entire staff was taken out to lunch. The officials from Hong Kong left immediately after lunch, saying they had a flight to take. When the analyst, sales and dealing teams got back to the office, they were barred entry and their ID cards were taken away. The agitated employees demanded an explanation but got none from the security people, whose only instructions were to prevent the employees from entering the office and to collect their IDs. Their possessions would be packed in boxes and handed to them the following day, the staff was told.

For the employees at foreign brokerages that downed shutters or fired staff, the downfall was hard to come to terms with. For one, they were earning twice or thrice more their counterparts at the local brokerage firms. And even if they were willing to take a hefty pay cut, there were not enough jobs going because of the market downturn.

The market was in a downtrend till mid-December, but the stock indices ended the year around 20 per cent higher over the previous year. This was no mean achievement, given the storm that roiled Asia during the second half of the year.

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I continued to meet up with Lucky over drinks, and in one of those sessions unwittingly mentioned my deal with Mouse to him. Lucky proposed that the three of us should meet, and against my better judgement, I agreed.

Mouse was reluctant to meet Lucky, but I managed to persuade him. The three of us met for dinner at the Jewel of India in Worli the following week. As the dinner progressed, I began to regret having arranged the meeting.

I could see that Lucky was subtly trying to flatter Mouse and tempt him with visions of big money. More worryingly for me, after a couple of pegs, Mouse was no longer his reserved self and seemed eager to impress Lucky. I tried signalling to him to quiet down, but Mouse was on his own trip, becoming more effusive by the minute. I was annoyed and let it show.